



PEOPLE OF THE WHOLE WORLD ARE POINTING TO THE SATELLITE

THE LAUNCH OF *SPUTNIK* (1957)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Space race

BEFORE

1926 Robert Goddard launches the world's first liquid-fueled rocket.

1942 Germany successfully launches the first ballistic missile, the A4, or V-2.

AFTER

1961 Alan Shepard commands *Freedom 7* on the first Mercury mission, becoming the first American in space.

July 20, 1969 American Neil Armstrong becomes the first man to set foot on the moon.

1971 Russia's *Salyut 1*, the world's first space station, is launched.

1997 A US rover named Sojourner wheels on to the surface of Mars to explore the surface.

2015 *Mars Reconnaissance Orbiter* finds water on Mars.

On October 4, 1957, the USSR launched the world's first artificial satellite, *Sputnik 1*. Carrying a simple radio transmitter to relay information about conditions in space, the satellite remained in orbit until January 4, 1958, when it reentered and burned up in Earth's atmosphere.

“That's one small step for [a] man, one giant leap for mankind.”
Neil Armstrong”

Sputnik symbolized far more than a scientific breakthrough. It was a sensational coup for the Soviets during the Cold War with the West. No shots were fired, but the military and political ramifications were immense. Americans felt more vulnerable to a nuclear attack. The USSR was now a Superpower, stunning the US and initiating the “space race,” a frantic competition between nations for technological superiority.

The US catches up

Sputnik was a mass-media event that ushered in the “Space Age,” capturing the world's collective imagination. There was a boom in science-fiction books, films, and TV dramas set in space. By 1958, the US had created NASA, the National Aeronautics and Space Administration, but they could only watch in envy as the Soviets sent Yuri Gagarin into orbit in 1961, the first human to go to outer space.

The US caught up by sending John Glenn into orbit in 1962, and by 1967 they had built a rocket, *Saturn V*, that was powerful enough to reach the moon. In 1969, 12 years after the launch of *Sputnik 1*, the American astronaut Neil Armstrong left *Apollo 11* and became the first man to walk on the moon. ■